



The day Anka saw her Friend

What are you so happy about, Anka? You didn't even appear for the exam!" Anka looked at her friend, blinking politely. This was a somewhat unusual situation. Was she not supposed to be happy if she didn't have a reason? Her friend, Suzie, was worried. She had just stepped out of the exam hall and found out that she hadn't answered an entire page of questions. She had simply forgotten to turn the page over! As her parents would chide her later, what a careless mistake!

Anka was slowly zoning out again. As Suzie continued her animated tirade about invigilators, marking schemes and re-evaluations, Anka felt her mind squeeze itself shut like a purse that's all clamped up. No. Nope. Nada. She could endure this no more.

Anka could feel Suzie's tension permeating through her skin and bones. She could see the beads of perspiration trickling down her pimpled, slightly red face. She was familiar with this path that her friend would often tread on. One thing led to another. First came the denial. Then the slowly sinking feeling of dread. Then the panic. Soon she would complain that she couldn't breathe and just feel guilty and inadequate. It's at this stage that Anka would feel like she was sitting next to a black hole. She would feel her own happiness drain out of her.

"Are you even listening to a word I'm saying? You shouldn't have stayed at home! You picked the wrong day for playing truant! What could have possibly been more important?"

Once again, Anka felt like the words were hurled at her from somewhere very far away. She found Suzie's questions illogical. They made her want to scream and run away. She felt like a soda bottle bubbling up to a point where she couldn't contain herself any longer. And then, peering through a haze of confusion, she could see Suzie's concern for what it truly was.

She can't tell that I am a different person, with different priorities. She feels like she is talking to herself. She feels as if she is looking into a mirror and scolding herself!

She cleared her throat. "Plenty!" she crisped. "There's lots of things in my life that are just as important as appearing in an exam."

Suzie gulped and cocked her head to one side, bewildered. Disappointed, even.

"Such as?" she asked derisively, in mock curiosity.

"Being happy."

As expected, Suzie looked hapless and mutinous. Fumbling, sputtering, looking for words and flailing her arms about like propellers, she resembled a mad windmill.

"How on earth could you be happy if you escape from an exam just because you feel you haven't prepared for it? How do you sleep at night knowing you're a coward or that you didn't raise the alarm at the right time at the right place?" Suzie blurted out,

telling herself that she was as good a friend as Anka was ever going to get. Surely this was the right thing to do. She was improving her friend, wasn't she?

“Because everything you just said is all about how YOU see the world. And I doubt if the same applies to me. Because I'm a different person.”

“Yes, but... “

“I'm me. And you are you. I'm not here to live up to your expectations. And you are not here to live up to mine.”

Suzie frowned and pursed her lips. Something stirred in her eyes, as she listened with her brow furrowed in deep concentration.

“Hang on. That's not you. That sounds like something I read in a book. Wait, I know which chapter... just give me some time...”

“I'm glad you could make a connection. I'm sure your memory will guide you to the chapter and even the page of the book you found this on. I just wish you could actually live it, though.

Use your intelligence to see what it means. And not just read it for an exam without understanding the words.”

“Are you calling me stupid? You're the one who didn't take the exam! Look, it's simple. You cannot have your parents pay the fees for an examination and then not turn up for it! That's just not done. That's letting your mind wander like a monkey! You've got to train it and bring it under control. When your mind plays games with you, you've got to play back!”

Suzie panted, feeling exhausted but jubilant. She was proud of herself and of how sorted she seemed right now. A part of her rejoiced knowing that she would always be more sorted than Anka.

“I hear you. I do. But what if I told you I feel happy nevertheless? What if I said I feel happy that I now have more time to prepare for the exam next year? What if I said that's one more fear struck off my list and I am now a little more confident of

striking out on my own?” Anka dangled her legs almost defiantly. Her glee seemed like an act of rebellion. It was too good to be allowed.

“And, Suzie, you should take that entrance exam for art. I saw your doodles in the textbook you are clinging to. You see colours far better than you see people.”

With that, Anka walked away, leaving behind a slightly stricken Suzie, looking at her doodles with a strange, new look in her eyes. Her eyes fell on a note Anka had slipped into her book.

‘Dearest Suzie,

There’s a poem by Emily Dickinson that I saw the other day. It evoked a lovely feeling in me. It compares hope to a bird and creates the same feeling I get when I listen to you talk. Lately, I feel you’re upset and heavy. Give it a read, will you? These are the lines I loved the most.

Love,

Anka’

“Hope” is the thing with feathers -
That perches in the soul -
And sings the tune without the words -
And never stops - at all -

I’ve heard it in the chilliest land -
And on the strangest Sea -
Yet - never - in Extremity,
It asked a crumb - of me.